

Chapter 19-1

Liang Shi didn't know how the original owner used to act in front of Xu Qingzhu's parents.

But there are many different ways to be bad in this world, while there's only one way to be good.

Pretending to be well-behaved wasn't Liang Shi's forte. She didn't have much experience interacting with elders, but when filming in production crews, many senior actors liked her very much.

So this matter wasn't difficult for her.

Currently, Xu Qingzhu's suggestion was most appropriate.

So she readily agreed.

"No need to pay rent," Liang Shi said. "Keep the second floor for yourself. I'll live on the first floor. When we get back, you can change the lock on the bedroom - that will give you more sense of security. However..."

She paused. "If your sister moves in, it seems we... temporarily can't live separately."

"So I'll persuade her to go back," Xu Qingzhu assured her. "No matter what method I use. When the time comes, she might act cute with you and try to convince you to let her stay. I hope you can be firm."

Liang Shi: "....."

When had she ever been not firm?

She looked over with a slightly confused expression. Xu Qingzhu pursed her lips lightly and turned her face away, saying: "You've always been unable to resist little girls acting cute."

Liang Shi: "....."

Ah, this.

The original owner indeed... seemed unable to resist.

Otherwise, she wouldn't have had so many "female confidantes."

"I'll change in the future," Liang Shi coughed lightly and immediately changed the topic. "Who's your sister's favorite celebrity?"

She wanted to see if there were any stars from her previous world here.

"Chen Zhengxuan¹," Xu Qingzhu said. "Seems to be an idol? From a boy band."

Liang Shi searched through all her memories and found she'd never heard of this person.

The entertainment industry here should be different from the one she'd stayed in before.

"I see," Liang Shi's tone carried a hint of disappointment.

"Do you know him?" Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow and asked.

Liang Shi shook her head. "How could I?"

After a slight pause, she asked again: "If I said I wanted to act, what would you think?"

Xu Qingzhu looked her up and down, her gaze settling on her eyes, and said meaningfully: "You should be a good actress."

Liang Shi: "....."

That didn't sound like a compliment.

But she didn't discuss this topic in depth with Xu Qingzhu. She didn't understand the entertainment industry here very well now. The original owner still had so many complicated family relationships and social networks - if she entered the entertainment industry, she might cause scandals at any time.

Most importantly, there was still that garbage system making her do tasks.

These three months were the critical period.

Whether she could survive depended on these three months.

It was just casual conversation, something she mentioned offhandedly.

Obviously, Xu Qingzhu didn't take her words seriously.

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The car drove past Jiangyuan Road, past Century Square, past Jinmao Building, past many of Haicheng's landmark buildings.

This place was quite different from where Liang Shi had lived before.

Because it was coastal, even the air was humid, carrying a faint salty taste.

This was Liang Shi's first time returning to the villa.

She'd been here for several days but had been in the hospital the whole time.

It was quite difficult.

When other people transmigrated into books, everything went smoothly and they became winners in life.

When she transmigrated into a book, she had to clean up messes and take care of her sister-in-law.

"....."

Liang Shi had just driven the car onto the main road when she saw Xu Qingya standing at the villa entrance.

Today's outfit was more well-behaved - T-shirt, jeans, white canvas shoes. She wasn't wearing heavy makeup either, standing by the roadside with her backpack, playing on her phone.

As soon as she saw their car approaching, Xu Qingya put away her phone, stuck her hands in her pockets, and wore an indifferent expression.

She was probably sulking with Xu Qingzhu.

Liang Shi drove the car into the courtyard. Xu Qingzhu unbuckled her seatbelt while saying: "You go back first. I'll take care of persuading her to leave."

Liang Shi: "....."

To avoid living under the same roof with her, Xu Qingzhu was working quite hard.

"I won't get out of the car first," Liang Shi said. "You go handle it. Call me when it's resolved."

Xu Qingzhu glanced at her and said reluctantly: "That works too."

Liang Shi's car had privacy film - you couldn't see inside from the outside, but you could clearly see what was happening outside from inside.

After Xu Qingzhu got out of the car, she said to Xu Qingya: "Either go home or go back to the hotel. Choose one."

"I choose the third option," Xu Qingya snorted lightly. "The hotel is too lonely, and I don't want to eat takeout."

"Then go home," Xu Qingzhu said. "Mom is still at home waiting for you."

"I already talked to Mom," Xu Qingya shrugged indifferently. "Mom told me to come to your place to calm down for a week."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

"Besides," Xu Qingya pouted, "If I stay at a hotel, wouldn't that still be wasting your money? If I stay here, just find me a small room. I definitely won't get in the way or be a third wheel."

"No," Xu Qingzhu still refused.

But Xu Qingya had already walked around the car to the driver's side and yanked open the car door.

Liang Shi, who was sitting in the driver's seat playing Snake: "?"

"Sister Liang Shi, tell me, isn't my sister being unreasonable?" Xu Qingya asked her to judge.

Liang Shi: ".....?"

She looked toward Xu Qingzhu.

Footnotes:

¹ Chen Zhengxuan (陈征绚): A fictional celebrity name in this story's universe, representing an idol from a boy band.

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Xu Qingzhu frowned and said: "Xu Qingya, stop making trouble, okay? Go home, or stay at a hotel. Just spend a few days outside to clear your head. Why do you have to come to my place? Do you think my life is too comfortable, so you want to come cause me trouble?"

Xu Qingya's expression cracked for a second, but a moment later she turned around, made a face at her, and said in a particularly annoying way: "Yeah, yeah."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

She pressed her temples with a headache.

"Are you even my sister? I'm about to become homeless, and you won't even let me stay for a few days." Xu Qingya complained with a hint of grievance. "Even Sister Liang Shi agreed to let me stay here. Why don't you agree?"

Liang Shi quickly waved her hands. "I'm not, I didn't."

Xu Qingya: "....."

She was silent for a moment, then said meaningfully: "Well, well, hen-pecked¹, huh."

Liang Shi: "....."

She just didn't want to be inexplicably punished by the system.

It hurt!

"I'm calling Uncle Liu right now to have him come pick you up." Afraid that Xu Qingya might discover her true intentions, Xu Qingzhu added: "If you were on vacation and wanted to stay at my place for a few days, that would be no problem. You could even stay for a whole vacation. But school starts in just a few days, and you fought with Dad. Dad's health isn't good - do you even remember that? When you ran away from home, did you consider his feelings?"

"When he tore up my idol's posters, did he consider my feelings?" Xu Qingya said coldly. "So you're the filial daughter and I'm just being unreasonable, right? I want to understand him too, but when his company isn't going well, he takes it out on me and still expects me to be magnanimous and forgive him. I don't understand that."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Finally, Xu Qingya even asked: "Sister Liang Shi, do you understand?"

Liang Shi: "....."

She didn't dare to understand.

"Dad was wrong in this matter." Xu Qingzhu still dialed Uncle Liu's number, but it rang for a long time with no answer.

Xu Qingya advised her: "Don't waste your effort. Uncle Liu is busy dismissing the household staff right now. He doesn't have time."

"Why?" Xu Qingzhu was puzzled.

Had the family situation become this dire? She had no idea.

"Mom doesn't want you to know, so just pretend you don't know, okay?" Xu Qingya put her hands in her pockets with a cool expression. "Just be a good Mrs. Liang here. I'll come stay at your house for a few days. Once this storm passes, I'll go back, or when school starts, I'll live in the dorms. I guarantee I won't disturb your couple's world. Is that okay, my dear sister?"

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Having said it to this extent.

If Xu Qingzhu still didn't agree, it would seem heartless.

She looked toward Liang Shi, who had been acting like a transparent person: ".....?"

"Should we let her stay then?" Liang Shi read Xu Qingzhu's expression and first posed it as a question. Seeing Xu Qingzhu breathe a slight sigh of relief, she said: "Let her stay. It's not like we don't have rooms here."

"Great!" Xu Qingya sweetly thanked her: "Thank you, sister."

"First tell me why the family is dismissing the staff?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Xu Qingya shrugged indifferently. "The company's financial situation isn't good. The family has no money and can't pay wages, so naturally they have to dismiss some people. These are all small matters."

"What small matters?" Xu Qingzhu said coldly. "Do we have to wait until the company goes bankrupt and we're selling houses and land before it counts as a big matter? Why didn't you tell me?"

"What's there to tell?" Xu Qingya said. "Dad isn't cut out for business - you know that. If it's going to go bankrupt, then let it go bankrupt. You're married now, so be a good Mrs. Liang and don't worry about the family's messy affairs, okay? As for us, even if we end up on the streets, we won't come trouble you. Just live well yourself, understand?"

She spoke with an arrogant tone, and her voice was somewhat aggressive.

After speaking, she turned and walked to the villa entrance to wait.

Leaving Xu Qingzhu standing alone at the door, thinking.

The family company was an enterprise left by her great-grandfather, flourished under her grandfather's management, then passed to her father, only to reach this desperate situation now.

This couldn't be allowed.

A fire ignited in Xu Qingzhu's heart, and she immediately wanted to go home to have it out with her father.

When she had used her marriage to exchange for the Liang family's financing, her father had said that with this money, he would definitely stage a beautiful comeback. But now what?

In less than half a year, they had fallen to the point of needing to dismiss household staff to cut costs.

"Lend me the car keys. I need to go out," Xu Qingzhu said.

From her expression, Liang Shi could guess her intention. "Going home? To confront your parents about this?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded.

"Let's not do that for now," Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingya on the other side was listening intently to their conversation, so Liang Shi moved a step closer and said: "Going back in this emotional state probably won't solve the problem. Besides, you don't understand the situation fully right now - what if there are other hidden circumstances? Moreover, it's lunchtime. Let's eat first and discuss this matter at length..."

Xu Qingzhu's gaze came over with some sharpness. Liang Shi awkwardly touched her nose tip and uncertainly added half a sentence: "That could work too, right?"

The word "right" came out as barely a whisper.

Xu Qingzhu looked at her, still thinking. At the entrance, Xu Qingya said lazily: "Can you stop dawdling? I'm starving to death."

Liang Shi wasn't sure she could persuade Xu Qingzhu, but Xu Qingzhu paused in place for a few seconds, then turned her face away somewhat awkwardly and rubbed her own ear.

Only then did Liang Shi realize she had gotten a bit too close to Xu Qingzhu.

She immediately stepped back half a step and sincerely apologized: "Sorry, I wasn't trying to..."

"It's fine." Xu Qingzhu interrupted her words, smoothly took her hand, leaned forward, and moved close to her ear. Warm breath brushed against her ear, carrying a hint of teasing heat that made Liang Shi's ear itch and her throat feel dry. She coughed unnaturally.

Xu Qingzhu's lips were a millimeter away from her ear. With just a slight move closer, their skin could touch.

Liang Shi's heart pounded, feeling like her heart was about to jump out.

Xu Qingzhu's slightly moist lips brushed past her ear as she said in a low voice: "Sorry for the trouble."

Her voice was low and husky, enchanting: "You'll need to help me put on an act."

Liang Shi: "....."

That was fine, but could she not get so close?

Footnotes:

¹ Hen-pecked (妻管嚴): A Chinese idiom literally meaning "strictly controlled by wife," referring to a husband who is dominated by his wife.